American Civil War

Introduction

> *In 1832 Alexis de Tocqueville warned that the US's demise will be "the presence of black slaves"*

In 1865-04-14, Abraham Lincoln is assassinated by a celebrated theater actor John Wilkes Booth, known for his sympathy towards the confederates. Lincoln is the first US president to be assassinated.
A few days earlier, confederate general Robert Lee ends the American civil war, defeated.
The Civil War caused over **600.000 deaths**
The war lasted 4 years and ended with the abolition of slavery in all the US states.

Context

US Economic and Demographic situation

- The US has about 31 million people at the end of the 18 hundreds. (More than the UK at that time, a bit less than France)
  - Incredible economic and demographic growth
  - Industrial growth (preeminently in the North)
  - Immigration from Europe (Italy, Ireland)
- Strong railway system in constant and rapid development → was built by underpaid immigrants
- Democratic society with universal voting (only males) → high “equality” (compared to European countries)
- Half of US presidents so far owned slaves.
- **Mason-Dixon Line**: Northern states in which slavery is abolished, Southern states where slavery is welcome.

Slave Trade

- 1807 Thomas Jefferson abolished the importation of slaves into the US → BUT slaves in the US could remain.
- Illegal trade continued nonetheless
- The consequence was a rise in cost and value of slaves
- France, UK, the Netherlands and Portugal supported the South in the illegal slave trade

Creation of Liberia

- Racism was strong, even the question of slavery was put into discussion. Freeing the slaves would have meant having free black men (considered inferior) in american society.
- To answer to the issue of slavery, abolitionists proposed to free black slaves in the US and to bring them back to Africa, in a new country named Liberia (from liberty)
- 1822 President James Monroe founded **Liberia**

Political Forces

Republican Party

Represented predominantly northern states, the industries and northern workers.

Democratic Party

Represented predominantly southern states and defended the land owners rights to expansion and slave ownership.
Dominated the political landscape (most US presidents were Southern). Pushed for the war with Mexico in 1848

The Senate

- Every State can send 2 senators to the Senate, no matter the size or population of the State
- South and North both tried to maximize the number of allied states to maximize the number of senators in the Senate
  - e.g. the creation of Maine: 2 more senator
- Robert Toombs speech about Texas in 1846 (even before it was conquered)

> Before God Almighty, if with your laws you will try to push us away from Texas and New Mexico, I will support the Secession

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The Southern States

Such as South Carolina, North Carolina, Georgia, Alabama, Virgina, Louisiana, Missisippi, Tennessee, Texas, Arkansas, Florida

- The **South** relies on the Cotton industry
  - Tobacco, rice and other crops were in decline
  - The Cotton is exported to the North and then to Europe: *"Cotton is King"*
  - Southern states' politician dominated the US political landscape, wealthy land and slave owners controlled the Capitol.
- Slavery produced enormous profits for the Cotton industry during the industrial revolution
- The south counted 4 million black slaves, and only 9 million total inhabitants.
- Scared by the Abolitionist Movement, southern politicians are forced to fight for the right of slavery
  - Because of the strength of the Abolitionist Movement in the North, southern politicians were politically obliged to publicly voice their support for slavery in order to be elected.
- Weaker military → 750.000 soldiers, more skilled but with less resources (weapons)
  - Soldiers also started to defect during the war as rich land owners who owned more than 40 slaves were not sent to battle, while "poorer" ones were.

The Northern States

Such as New York, Vermont, Massachussets, Wisconsin, Connecticut, Michigan, Illinois, Kansas, California

- The **North** has 3/4th of the US citizens, but has almost the totality of the **industry**
- Population of 20 million people → also immigrants, black people and indians.
- Efficient railroad system, very industrialized thanks to the growing settlement of immigrants from Europe.
- Fear of the **Slave Power** → large groups of slave owners and land owners plotting against the North.
- Strong military → almost 3 million soldiers.

Abolition of Slavery

- 1833 Abolition of slavery in the UK
- Economic system of the North was based on the labor of immigrants and workers. Slowly, labor uninions formed and workers developed a conciousness of worker's rights.
- **For what reasons slavery was abolished?**
  - Unpaid slaves constituted a **direct and unfari competition** with paid white workers (slaves were more convenient) → Protests from unions
    - John Addams (2nd US President):
      "White workers did not allow the rich to turn to black slaves."
    - Italian and Irish immigrants exported mafia to the US. Owners relied on armed guerrillas to control their factories → they often relied on the mafia.
  - Slaves would have been had to be taught to work in a factory → when you teach slaves to work, you risk them organizing revolutions
  - **Discrimination** and **racism** against black people was strong nonetheless
  - Slaves would not have been able to find work in the North → they were forced to do the only job no one else wanted to do
  - Some (few) owners refused slavery on moral grounds
- Abolitionist Movement: movement in the northern elite that argued for the abolishment of slavery on moral grounds
  - They began organizing themselves into the Republican Party
  - Uncle Tom's Cabin , a antislavery novel

The West

- The **West** was expanding and developing.
  - Initially a purely agricultural economy.
  - Some states decide to implement slavery, others banish it.
  - As the West developed, thanks to the railway system it became more and more economically dependent on the North.

Territorial Expansion

- When white colonizers expanded westwards, they could ask for recognition, creating a "US Territory"
- When the white population increases, the territory officially becomes a US State

The Question of Slavery

- Southern state push for new States to implement slavery, so that southern land owners could expand into the new states.
  - When the US conquered Texas by southern States, slavery was reintroduced.
- Northern states pushed for the abolishment of slavery
- Western colonizers realize that slavery is inconvenient for them
  - The West is more and more economically tied with the North (with railways)
  - Slaves would be direct competition to the white colonizers
  - Agriculture is modernized thanks to Northern industrial advance

New States

- California → Debate on slavery turns into a compromise: California won't allow slavery, but Federal police must hunt and arrest slaves who ran away from slave-owning states
  - the Abolitionist Movement grows along with a discontent towards this agreement.

- **Kansas** → the North assumed it would be slave-free, but the South made it so the decision would be left to a popular vote by the citizens of Kansas
  - the North and the South rushed to move people into Kansas in order to swing the vote → violences Bleeding Kansas

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The Tariffs Crisis

- States involved: South Carolina, UK, France
- Context of the cotton export
  - The South would export cotton to the North, where it would be processed in its industries
  - The demand for cotton was very high (e.g. jeans)
  - Fabrics, colorants and other raw materials were imported from Europe
  - The tariffs were thought as a way to reduce competition from Europe and to reduce their independence on Europe
- The North pushed for duties (federal tariffs) which would favor the industrial economy of the North
  - 1832 Washington passes a law increasing tariffs
  - Northern politicians argue that federal laws should be applied to all US states and that the Union is a single, united nation.
- The South thrived in exporting cotton freely with the North and with Europe, especially to the UK
  - Southern politicians argued that states were not obliged to follow laws imposed by Washington
  - **South Carolina rejected the 1832 law on duties**: South Carolina Nullification Crisis
  - John Calhoun argues that in the Union, individual states maintains total independence from the laws of Washington. The US are not a single nation.

Bleeding Kansas

- Kansas is a new US State that needs to decide whether to implement slavery or not.
- As a compromise in the Senate between South and North, it is decided that Kansas' population will vote on the question of slavery
- Population from North and South immigrate to Kansas in order to secure a majority in the vote on slavery
- **Sacking of Lawrence** (1856-05-21): a guerrilla of southern citizens attacks Lawrence, a town of northern citizens, destroying local abolitionist newspapers
- **Massacre of Pottawatomie** (1856-05-24): a guerrilla of abolitionists target southern colonizers families. The guerrilla was lead by John Brown (an abolitionist leader)
- Kansas decides on abolishing slavery, but black men/slaves would not be allowed to enter the state.

Dred Scott v. Sandford

Dred Scott v. Sandford, 60 U.S. 393, was a landmark decision of the United States Supreme Court that held the U.S. Constitution did not extend American citizenship to people of black African descent, and thus they could not enjoy the rights and privileges the Constitution conferred upon American citizens.

- Dred Scott was the black slave of a military medic → he lived in states where slavery was allowed as well as in states where it was abolished.
- At the death of his owner, he argued that he should be considered a free man as he lived for a long time in abolitionist
- The US Supreme Court decides in 1857 that

- 1. Dred Scott is a slave and as such has no right to appeal US courts
- 2. the decision on slavery by the US Congress has no influence on the individual States' laws on slavery

Harpers Ferry Raid

- In 1859, John Brown, after Kansas, plans to arm black slaves to organize a revolt by rallying slaves from southern states.
- **Brown intended to arm slaves with weapons from the armory, but only a few slaves joined his revolt**. Those of Brown's men who had not fled were killed or captured by local militia and U.S. Marines, the latter led by Robert Lee.

Republican Party

- After these events, the **Republican Party** is born and presents itself at the next elections to reppresent the interests of the Northern States.
- The frontrunner of the new party was Abraham Lincoln, a citizen from the West, extremely moderated, who was able to channel the will of the citizens.
- He didn't scare the south as he was not an abolitionist and wanted to allow sovreignty to the single states on the matter.
  - Nonetheless, he believed that slavery was a dividing factor in the country and that one day or the other, slavery or the abolition of it would overtake the entirety of the US. The government cannot endure half slave and half free states.
- In the elections, Abraham Lincoln does not get any votes from the South → southern citizens had to vote in public, so no one was allowed to vote for Lincoln.
- In the North, Lincoln was strongly supported due to his economic policies.

1860 Elections

- 4 candidates ran in the elections:
  - Abraham Lincoln → Republican Party, initially neutral on slavery but then against it
  - Stephen Douglas → Democratic Party, anti-slavery and from Illinois
  - John Breckenridge → Democratic Party, pro-slavery from the Southern faction
  - John Bell → Constitutional Union Party, slavery-neutral and from Tennessee
- In the elections, Lincoln carried every Northern state except Maryland and Delaware, while he did not carry a single state in the South → clear division between North and South

The Confederate States of America

- After Abraham Lincoln's election, **South Carolina** withdrew from the Union.
- **1861 foundation of the Confederation** → meeting in Montgomery, Alabama where Jefferson Davis was elected president.
- 11 States joined the Confederation → South Carolina, Mississippi, Florida, Alabama, **Georgia**, Louisana and Texas – *Virgina, arkansas, Tennessee and North Carolina*.
- Founded to defend Slavery, but hid behind the belief that its true purpose was to defend the constitutional right of every state of sovereignty.
- The **Confederate Constitution** established the **sovereignty and independence of each state**, and guaranteed the **right** of Southerners to **own slaves**.

Fort Sumter: Casus Belli

- After Abraham Lincoln inaugural presidential speech, the seceded southern states declare that all Federal properties in their states shall be confiscated
- Fort Sumter in South Carolina is the only federal military installation that attempts to resist → The Confederate States attacked the fort.
- Abraham Lincoln enrolled an army of 70.000 men to protect Fort Sumter and to suppress the rebellion of southern states.
- The Civil War begins on 1861-04-12
- 1863 Abraham Lincoln issued the **Emancipation Proclamation**, which stated that all **persons previously held as slaves shall be free.**

Influence of France, UK and Italy

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Causes of the Civil War

- Different economic models
- Tariffs imposed by the North
- Increasing social antagonism between North and South
- Territorial expansion and the question of slavery in new states

The Civil War

- The blue Northern troops were commanded by Ulysses Grant
- The grey Southern troops were commanded by Robert Lee
- New weapons engaged in the war
  - Deadlier cannons and bullets
  - Accurate rifles
  - Ironclad ships → iron plates that protected them from cannon fire
- 1863-07 **Battle of Gettysburg** → the bloodiest battle, 3 days.
  - Last attempt of the South to invade the North
  - the Union won the battle
- 1863-11 **Gettysburg Address** → Abraham Lincoln delivered a speech at the dedication of the Soldier's National Cemetery in Gettysburg.
- In 1865-04-09 confederate general Robert Lee surrendered to Ulysses Grant in Texas → end of the Civil War.
- The Civil War caused over **600.000 deaths** → The war ended after 4 years with the abolition of slavery in all the US states.

After the War

- Frederick Douglas → Prominent Abolitionist and formerly enslaved person. During the Civil War, Douglass was **a consultant to President Abraham Lincoln and helped convince him that slaves should serve in the Union forces and that the abolition of slavery should be a goal of the war**
- Abolition of slavery was sanctioned by the 14th **Amendment to the Constitution** → black slaves were freed, but without economical support nor housing.
  - This motion was taken to gain the support of Great Britain and France

    - Some migrated to the **industrial cities in the North**
    - Some remained with their **old masters in the South** → they would be given a share of the crops, tools and a cabin
    - Black workers would often get employed as **apprentices** → they would be considered workers, but they were still treated as unpaid slaves.
- In 1865-04-14, Abraham Lincoln is assassinated by a celebrated theater actor John Wilkes Booth, known for his sympathy towards the confederates. Lincoln is the first US president to be assassinated.
- Southern states attempted to distort the narration on the war → the war wasn't about slavery, but about **constitutional freedom** →
    - The Lost Cause (1899) by Edward Pollard → He was a pro-confederate journalist and revisionist. He argued that the US Constitution gave states the independence and the right to choose the laws they wanted (such as on the question of slavery)
- **Violence towards black people**
    - Foundation of the **Ku Klux Klan** → violence towards black people, killings and torture
    - **Black codes** → segregation of black people in schools, hospitals and transport
- 1894 Foundation of **The United Daughters of the Confederacy (UDC)** → pushed for the creation of Confederate memorials and statues and grew in popularity.
    - Presidents Howard Taft and Woodrow Wilson allowed for the celebration of the Confederacy thanks to the influence of the UDC → The UDC exists up to this day.

Economic Consequences

- The economy of the **South collapsed** during the war
- **Northern** states **increased industrial output** to supply military needs
- Rise of "self-made" entrepreneurs, such as John Rockefeller (who controlled the oil industry in America)
- 1866 Foundation of the **American Federation of Labor** (AFL) to contrast exploitation of the workforce → it was the strongest group of trade unions.

Textbook Notes

Difference between North and South

- **Economy** → South realized on vast plantations of tobacco, cotton and on slavery. The North was industrialized.
- **Population** → South counted 4 million black slaves and was rigidly divided in classes. The North was much much denser and more populous due to immigration from Europe.
- **Emancipation** → The South argued that slavery empowered slaves as the international demand for cotton relied on the southern production, while the North started adopting emancipation since the 1830s

The Civil War

- Northern abolitionists organized themselves into a political movement → the Republican Party, formerly known as the WHigh Party → demanded that slavery be abolished from all territories of the Union.
- After Abraham Lincoln's election, 11 southern States seceded and formed the Confederate States of America, under the presidency of Jefferson Davis.
- Abraham Lincoln refused to concede that any American State had the constitutional right to withdraw from the UNion → the Civil War broke out in 1861.

- The war ended 4 years later, in 1865 when northern troops commanded by Ulysses Grant defeated the Confederates led by Robert Lee.
- 5 days later, Abraham Lincoln was assassinated by John Wilkes Booth, a southern fanatic.
- The Civil War determined the kind of nation the US would be → indivisible with a sovereign national government and the abolition of slavery.

The abolition of slavery

- The abolition of slavery was sanctioned by the 14th Amendment to the Constitution in 1865, but it did not grant the blacks equality or economic security.
- A wave of **resentment** and violence, embodied by the racist **Ku Klux Klan**, terrorised black families.
- The **black codes** were created → **segregation** of blacks in schools, hospitals and means of transport.

The expansion and settlement in the West

- The expansion in the West was encouraged by the discovery of gold in California → **gold rush.**
- The **Homestead Act** of 1862 granted free soil to first occupants → rush to the West.
- The migration towards the west had consequences:
  - **Disappearance of the frontier** → the advancing border that marked the lands that had been settled by Europeans
  - **Extermination of buffaloes**
  - **Starvation of American Indians**
  - **Subjugation**, deportation and extermination of American Indians
- **Cattlemen** became the new Western symbol → cowboys

Example Questions